
BSc NURSING

Professionalism, Ethics & Bioethics

Comprehensive Examination Study Guide & Master Notes

Combined Topics: Long Answer, Short Notes & Very Short Q&A;

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SECTION 1: LONG ANSWER QUESTIONS (LAG)

Profession

Definition

A **profession** is an occupation that requires specialized education, training, and skill. It is based on a body of knowledge and serves society with a specific code of ethics and standards.

Key Points

- A profession is different from a job or trade because it needs long formal education.
- Members of a profession have a social responsibility.
- Professions are regulated by codes of ethics and standards.
- Nursing is considered a profession because it has its own knowledge base, education, ethics, and service to society.

Detailed Explanation

A profession has these important features:

1. **Specialized Knowledge** – A profession is based on a well-defined body of knowledge learned through formal education.
2. **Education and Training** – Long period of study and practical training is required.
3. **Service Orientation** – The main goal is to serve people and society, not only to earn money.
4. **Code of Ethics** – Professionals follow ethical rules to protect clients and society.
5. **Autonomy** – Professionals can make independent decisions within their field.
6. **Accountability** – Professionals are responsible for their actions.
7. **Professional Organization** – Professions have associations that set standards and support members.
8. **Continuing Education** – Professionals keep learning throughout their career.

Bullet Summary

- Profession = specialized knowledge + formal education + ethics + service
- Features: knowledge, education, service, ethics, autonomy, accountability, organization, lifelong learning

- Nursing is a profession because it has all these features.

Quick Remember Box

PROFESSION

Protected by ethics

Responsible and accountable

Organized body of knowledge

Formal education and training

Education is long and specialized

Service to society

Self-regulated profession

Independent decision making

Ongoing learning

National/international organizations

Example

A nurse is a professional because she has studied nursing science, follows the Indian Nursing Council Code of Ethics, is accountable for patient care, and is a member of the Trained Nurses' Association of India (TNI).

Ethics, Ethical Committee, Bioethics, and Code of Ethics

Definition

- **Ethics** is the study of what is right and wrong in human behavior. It helps people decide the morally correct action.
- **Bioethics** is the study of ethical issues in healthcare, biology, and life sciences.
- **Ethical Committee** is a group of people who review and guide ethical decisions, especially in research and patient care.
- **Code of Ethics** is a written set of rules that tells professionals how to behave.

Key Points

- Ethics guides correct behavior.
- Bioethics deals with moral problems in healthcare.
- Ethical committees protect patients and research participants.
- Code of ethics gives rules for professional conduct.

Detailed Explanation

1. Ethics

Ethics comes from the Greek word "ethos" meaning character or custom. It deals with moral principles like:

- Right and wrong
- Good and bad
- Justice and fairness
- Duty and responsibility

In nursing, ethics helps nurses make decisions that respect patients and protect their welfare.

2. Bioethics

Bioethics applies ethics to healthcare and life sciences. It includes issues like:

- Patient consent
- End-of-life care
- Organ donation
- Abortion
- Genetic testing
- Research on humans

3. Ethical Committee

An ethical committee (also called Ethics Committee or Institutional Ethics Committee) reviews:

- Research proposals involving humans or animals

- Patient care decisions when there is confusion
- Cases of ethical dilemmas

Members usually include:

- Doctors
- Nurses
- Lawyers
- Social workers
- Community members
- Religious leaders

Functions:

- Protect patient rights
- Review research proposals
- Give ethical guidance
- Solve ethical dilemmas

4. Code of Ethics

A code of ethics is a written guide for professionals. It tells members:

- How to behave
- What their duties are
- How to treat clients
- What to do in difficult situations

The Indian Nursing Council (INC) Code of Ethics gives rules for nurses in India.

Bullet Summary

- Ethics = moral principles of right and wrong
- Bioethics = ethics in healthcare and life sciences
- Ethical Committee = group that reviews ethical issues in research and care
- Code of Ethics = written rules for professional behavior
- All four protect patients, society, and professional standards.

Quick Remember Box

EBEC

Ethics = right vs wrong

Bioethics = healthcare ethics

Ethical Committee = review and guide

Code of Ethics = written rules for nurses

Example

When a hospital wants to start a new drug trial on patients, the Ethical Committee reviews the plan. It checks informed consent, patient safety, and privacy. The nurse follows the Code of Ethics while caring for the trial participants.

Ethical Committee

Definition

An **Ethical Committee** (also called **Ethics Committee** or **Institutional Review Board**) is a group of experts and community members who review and guide ethical decisions in healthcare and research.

Key Points

- It protects the rights, safety, and welfare of patients and research participants.
- It reviews research proposals before they start.
- It helps solve ethical dilemmas in patient care.
- It makes sure laws and ethical standards are followed.

Detailed Explanation

Purpose

1. **Protect Patients** – Ensures patients are treated fairly and safely.
2. **Review Research** – Checks that research involving humans or animals is ethical.
3. **Guidance** – Gives advice on ethical problems in healthcare.
4. **Education** – Teaches staff about ethics and patient rights.

Composition

An ethical committee usually includes:

- Chairperson (senior doctor or professor)
- Medical doctors
- Nurses
- Pharmacists
- Lawyers
- Social workers
- Religious or spiritual leaders
- Community representatives
- Lay persons (non-medical public members)

Functions

- Approve or reject research proposals
- Monitor ongoing research
- Review informed consent forms
- Investigate complaints about ethical violations
- Advise on end-of-life decisions
- Help in organ donation and transplantation ethics
- Make policies for ethical patient care

Types of Committees

1. **Institutional Ethics Committee (IEC)** – For hospitals and institutions.
2. **Research Ethics Committee (REC)** – For research projects.
3. **Clinical Ethics Committee** – For clinical care decisions.

Bullet Summary

- Ethical Committee = group that reviews ethics in healthcare/research
- Members: doctors, nurses, lawyers, social workers, community members
- Functions: protect patients, review research, solve dilemmas, educate staff
- Types: IEC, REC, Clinical Ethics Committee

Quick Remember Box

ETHICS COMMITTEE

Evaluates research and patient care

Teaches staff about ethics

Helps solve ethical dilemmas

Investigates complaints

Checks informed consent

Safeguards patient rights

Example

A hospital wants to test a new cancer medicine. The Ethical Committee reviews the trial, checks that patients will give informed consent, and monitors their safety. Without committee approval, the research cannot start.

SECTION 2: SHORT ANSWER NOTES

Code of Ethics in Nursing

Definition

A **Code of Ethics** is a written set of rules that guides the behavior of nurses. It tells nurses what is right and wrong in professional practice.

Key Points

- The Indian Nursing Council (INC) Code of Ethics is used in India.
- It protects patients and maintains professional standards.
- It includes duties towards patients, society, profession, and coworkers.

Detailed Explanation

The Code of Ethics for nurses includes:

1. **Respect for patients** – Treat every patient with dignity and respect their privacy.
2. **Compassion and care** – Provide kind and considerate care to all patients.
3. **Honesty** – Be truthful in all professional activities.
4. **Confidentiality** – Do not share patient information without permission.
5. **Accountability** – Take responsibility for your nursing actions.
6. **Competence** – Practice only within your knowledge and skills.
7. **Justice** – Treat all patients fairly, without discrimination.
8. **Professional loyalty** – Support and maintain the dignity of the nursing profession.

Bullet Summary

- Code of Ethics = written rules for nurses
- Made by: Indian Nursing Council (INC)
- Covers: respect, compassion, honesty, confidentiality, accountability, competence, justice, loyalty
- Purpose: protect patients and guide nurses

Quick Remember Box

CODE

Compassionate care

Obedience to standards

Dignity and respect

Ethical behavior always

Example

If a nurse learns that a patient has HIV, she must not tell anyone except the healthcare team involved in care. This is confidentiality as per the Code of Ethics.

TNI – Trained Nurses' Association of India

Definition

TNI stands for the **Trained Nurses' Association of India**. It is a national professional organization for nurses in India.

Key Points

- Founded in 1908 (earlier as the Association of Nursing Superintendents).
- It is one of the oldest nursing organizations in India.
- It works for the welfare and professional growth of nurses.

Detailed Explanation

Objectives

1. **Promote nursing education** – Improve the quality of nursing education in India.
2. **Professional development** – Provide training, workshops, and conferences for nurses.

- 3. Welfare of nurses** – Protect the rights and interests of nurses.
- 4. Standards of care** – Help maintain high standards of nursing practice.
- 5. Publication** – Publishes the Indian Journal of Nursing and Midwifery (IJNM).
- 6. Networking** – Connects nurses across India.

Activities

- Organizing conferences and seminars
- Offering continuing education programs
- Publishing nursing journals
- Representing nurses in government committees
- Supporting nurses' welfare and professional rights

Importance

- TNI gives nurses a united voice.
- It helps improve the status of nursing in India.
- It encourages research and evidence-based practice.

Bullet Summary

- TNI = Trained Nurses' Association of India
- Founded: 1908
- National professional body for nurses
- Objectives: education, development, welfare, standards, publication, networking
- Publishes: Indian Journal of Nursing and Midwifery

Quick Remember Box

TNI

Trained nurses united

National organization

Improve nursing profession

Example

A nurse in Delhi wants to attend a workshop on critical care nursing. She can join TNI to get updates about workshops, conferences, and nursing journals.

Professional Values in Nursing

Definition

Professional values are the beliefs and principles that guide nurses in their work. They help nurses decide what is right and important in patient care.

Key Points

- Professional values shape nursing behavior.
- They are learned during nursing education and practice.
- They include caring, honesty, respect, responsibility, and justice.

Detailed Explanation

Important professional values in nursing:

1. **Caring** – Showing concern and kindness for patients.
2. **Compassion** – Understanding and sharing the feelings of patients.
3. **Respect** – Honoring patients' dignity, culture, and choices.
4. **Honesty** – Being truthful with patients and colleagues.
5. **Accountability** – Accepting responsibility for one's actions.
6. **Justice** – Treating all patients fairly.
7. **Integrity** – Following moral principles even when difficult.
8. **Altruism** – Putting patient needs before personal comfort.
9. **Excellence** – Trying to give the best possible care.
10. **Autonomy** – Respecting patients' right to make their own decisions.

Bullet Summary

- Professional values = beliefs that guide nursing behavior
- Main values: caring, compassion, respect, honesty, accountability, justice, integrity, altruism, excellence, autonomy
- These values help build trust between nurses and patients.

Quick Remember Box

NURSE VALUES

Nurturing and caring

Unconditional respect

Responsibility and accountability

Service and altruism

Excellence in care

Example

A nurse stays late to comfort a patient who is scared before surgery. This shows the values of caring, compassion, and altruism.

Ethical Principles in Nursing

Definition

Ethical principles are basic moral rules that guide nurses in making right decisions. They help protect patients and promote good care.

Key Points

- The main ethical principles are autonomy, beneficence, non-maleficence, justice, fidelity, and veracity.
- These principles help nurses solve ethical problems.

Detailed Explanation

- 1. Autonomy** – Respect the patient's right to make their own decisions. The patient has the right to accept or refuse treatment.

- Example: A patient has the right to refuse surgery.
- 2. Beneficence** – Do good and promote the welfare of patients.
- Example: Giving pain relief to a patient in pain.
- 3. Non-maleficence** – Do no harm. Avoid actions that may hurt the patient.
- Example: Checking a patient's allergy before giving medicine.
- 4. Justice** – Treat all patients fairly and equally. No discrimination based on caste, religion, gender, or money.
- Example: Giving emergency care to all patients equally.
- 5. Fidelity** – Be faithful and keep promises to patients. Maintain trust.
- Example: If a nurse promises to return with medicine, she must come back.
- 6. Veracity** – Be truthful and honest with patients.
- Example: Telling a patient the correct side effects of a medicine.

Bullet Summary

- Autonomy = respect patient's choice
- Beneficence = do good
- Non-maleficence = do no harm
- Justice = fair treatment
- Fidelity = keep promises
- Veracity = tell the truth

Quick Remember Box

ABJFV

Autonomy – respect choice

Beneficence – do good

Justice – be fair

Fidelity – keep trust

Veracity – be truthful

(And always remember Non-maleficence = do no harm)

Example

A nurse explains all treatment options to a patient, respects the patient's decision, and gives safe care. This follows autonomy, beneficence, and non-maleficence.

SECTION 3: VERY SHORT ANSWER QUESTIONS

Nursing Criteria

Definition

Nursing criteria are the standards or requirements used to judge good nursing practice and education.

Key Points

- Criteria help evaluate nursing care and nursing programs.
- They ensure quality and safety in nursing practice.
- Criteria may include knowledge, skills, ethics, and attitudes.

Detailed Explanation

Common criteria for nursing include:

1. **Knowledge** – Understanding nursing science, anatomy, physiology, and diseases.
2. **Skills** – Ability to perform procedures like injections, wound dressing, and vital signs monitoring.
3. **Attitude** – Professional behavior, empathy, and respect for patients.
4. **Ethics** – Following the nursing code of ethics.
5. **Competence** – Ability to provide safe and effective care.
6. **Communication** – Clear and respectful communication with patients and team.

Bullet Summary

- Nursing criteria = standards to judge nursing practice/education
- Includes: knowledge, skills, attitude, ethics, competence, communication
- Used to maintain quality patient care.

Quick Remember Box

K-S-A-E-C-C

Knowledge

Skills

Attitude

Ethics

Competence

Communication

Example

A nursing college is judged by criteria such as qualified teachers, good laboratories, clinical training, and student results.

Values in Nursing

Definition

Values in nursing are the beliefs and ideals that influence how nurses think, act, and care for patients.

Key Points

- Values guide nurses in daily practice.
- They help nurses make good decisions.
- Important nursing values include honesty, respect, caring, and responsibility.

Detailed Explanation

Values in nursing are important because they:

1. Build trust between nurse and patient.
2. Improve quality of care.

3. Guide ethical behavior.
4. Support teamwork.
5. Help nurses face difficult situations.

Core nursing values:

- **Patient-centered care** – Putting the patient first.
- **Respect** – Honoring patient dignity and choices.
- **Compassion** – Showing kindness and understanding.
- **Integrity** – Being honest and ethical.
- **Excellence** – Striving for the best care.

Bullet Summary

- Values = beliefs that guide nursing actions
- Important values: respect, compassion, integrity, excellence, patient-centered care
- Values improve trust, care quality, and ethical practice.

Quick Remember Box

CARE VALUES

Compassion

Accountability

Respect

Excellence

Example

A nurse explains a procedure to a patient calmly and honestly. This shows the values of respect, veracity, and compassion.

Ethical Dilemma

Definition

An **ethical dilemma** is a situation where a person must choose between two or more options, and each option has both right and wrong aspects. It is a difficult choice between conflicting moral values.

Key Points

- In an ethical dilemma, there is no clear right answer.
- Different ethical principles may conflict.
- Nurses often face ethical dilemmas in patient care.

Detailed Explanation

Common Causes

- Conflict between patient choice and medical advice
- Confidentiality vs. safety
- Family wishes vs. patient wishes
- Limited resources vs. patient need

Examples in Nursing

1. A patient refuses life-saving treatment due to religious beliefs.
2. A family asks the nurse not to tell the patient about a cancer diagnosis.
3. There is only one ventilator and two patients need it.

How to Resolve

1. Identify the problem clearly.
2. Gather all information.
3. Think about ethical principles involved.
4. Consider all options.
5. Consult with the healthcare team and ethics committee.
6. Choose the option that causes the least harm and respects patient rights.

Bullet Summary

- Ethical dilemma = conflict between two morally right choices
- Causes: patient choice, confidentiality, family wishes, limited resources
- Resolution: gather facts, consider principles, consult team, choose least harmful option

Quick Remember Box

DILEMMA

Difficult choice

Involves values conflict

Leads to stress

Ethical reasoning needed

Multiple options

May need committee help

Action should respect patient rights

Example

A pregnant woman refuses blood transfusion because of her faith. The doctor believes it is needed to save her life. The nurse faces an ethical dilemma between respecting autonomy and doing good (beneficence).

Professional Value

Definition

Professional value refers to the worth and importance of being a member of a profession. It includes the respect, dignity, and social recognition given to professionals because of their knowledge, skills, and service to society.

Key Points

- Professional value means the positive qualities of a profession.

- It comes from education, ethics, and service.
- Nursing has professional value because nurses save lives and promote health.

Detailed Explanation

Sources of Professional Value

1. **Education** – Long and specialized training.
2. **Skill** – Ability to perform important healthcare tasks.
3. **Knowledge** – Understanding of health and disease.
4. **Ethics** – Commitment to moral behavior.
5. **Service** – Helping society and individuals.
6. **Responsibility** – Accountability for patient care.

Why Nursing Has Professional Value

- Nurses care for the sick, weak, and vulnerable.
- Nursing requires scientific knowledge and practical skills.
- Nurses work in hospitals, communities, schools, and homes.
- Nurses promote health, prevent disease, and support recovery.

Bullet Summary

- Professional value = worth and dignity of a profession
- Sources: education, skill, knowledge, ethics, service, responsibility
- Nursing has high professional value because of its service to society.

Quick Remember Box

VALUE

Vital service to society

Accountable professionals

Learned and skilled

Unique knowledge base

*Ethical practice***Example**

Society respects doctors and nurses because they use specialized knowledge to save lives and reduce suffering. This respect is the professional value of nursing.